

Cabinet

Perhaps the most ignored system component is the trusty system cabinet—most of us spared it a serious thought only at the time of purchase, when we chose its colour and shape! The fact is that the system cabinet dictates how many drives you can have in your system, whether you can add additional ports and even how cool your system remains. If you find that after your recent CPU upgrade, your system has begun heating up, especially after long periods of use, it could mean that your processor is running slightly hotter than it should. Choosing a larger and roomier cabinet would free you from this problem. Larger cabinets also have the facility for adding cooling fans to dissipate heat within the cabinet.



Also a part of your system cabinet, your SMPS is the powerhouse that delivers clean power of varying voltages to the various components in your system. By default, most SMPS units have a power rating of 235 watts. While this is suitable for most computers, the moment you add more peripherals or a faster processor, you will begin to load the SMPS. If you have just installed an Athlon XP 2100+, a GeForce 3 graphics card and a 40x CD-Writer and are raring to go, only to find that your system has suddenly become very unstable, it could simply be due to your older SMPS being overloaded.

Audio System

Another component that most people don't give due attention to, unless they are building a home theatre system around their computer, is the audio system. Comprising a soundcard and speakers, this is the subsystem that sees you through all those movies and MP3 songs. There's nothing more outrageous than watching *The Fast and the Furious* on a pokey little stereo speaker system. The good news



is that upgrading to a more serious audio system is more affordable than ever today with Dolby Digital soundcards available for well under Rs 3,000 and a six-channel speaker system, suitable for most home users, starting at Rs 5,000. Even if you have a stereo soundcard, you can use a technology such as Dolby Headphone to simulate surround sound from two channels.

Input Devices

Finally, we come to the input devices on your computer system. Your keyboard and your mouse are the two things with which you are in almost permanent contact with while using your computer. They are your interfaces to all the power that lies within the beige box.



In fact, Microsoft Windows Me even goes

so far as calling them 'human interface devices'! When you bought your keyboard and mouse, if you simply settled for one that had the most number of buttons or funkier colours, you're probably feeling the repercussions now as you try to get the hang of the keys. This will adversely affect your productivity as you will take longer to type and navigate your way through the Windows interface. In this case, it is you who are the bottleneck in your system! Choosing comfort and functionality over design and colour is indeed a wise choice when it comes to input devices.

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Tips & Tweaks

- When buying a new cabinet, see that it has at least three 5.25-inch drive bays to allow for further addition of devices such as a CD-RW drive.
- See that your cabinet has enough room for additional cooling fans.
- You can also modify your casing and add additional fans to achieve greater levels of airflow within the system to facilitate more efficient cooling.
- To keep the components free from moisture, place a packet of silica gel inside your system cabinet.

- Four-channel soundcards are now available for as low as Rs 800. Teamed up with a sub-Rs 2,000 four-channel speaker system, this is a great 'bare minimum' when it comes to home theatre on your computer.
- If given a choice, go for a speaker system that features a digital input as this gives a much better sound quality compared to analogue inputs, especially in the case of surround sound audio.
- Keep your soundcard driver and DirectX versions updated as this ensures that your soundcard is operating with the highest efficiency and audio quality.

- Before buying a keyboard or mouse, insist that you try it out for comfort. A mouse should fit in your hand comfortably—take this into consideration especially if you have large or small hands.
- Clean your mouse rollers and dust the keyboard with a brush as often as you can. Dust buildup can cause your input devices to function erratically and this can get really frustrating!